

504

THE NUMBER OF STATUES AT BOROBUDUR TEMPLE

THE TIBETAN EMPIRE EXPANDED

in the early part of the 9th century, and extended its control to the Bay of Bengal. Its influence in Central Asia was indicative of **Tang China's** weakness in the region. Meanwhile, in northern India, the **Gurjara-Pratihara dynasty**, which had united the region and held back the advance of Islam, continued to grow in strength with the conquest of Kanauj in modern-day India by **Nagabhata II**, around 801.

The **Temple of Borobudur**, a **Buddhist monument** in central Java, Southeast Asia, was completed in the early 9th century. The colossal structure, which is the largest Buddhist monument in the world, contains over **2 million stone blocks** and is covered in almost 21,500 sq ft (2,000 sq m) of carvings. The monument is a three-dimensional *mandala*, or cosmic wheel; walking its path, which is a journey of over 2 miles (3 km), reenacts the journey toward nirvana (enlightenment). Its construction was an epic achievement, and a testament to the power of the **Srivijayan Empire** (c. 760–1402), which had grown rich from the extensive maritime trade of the region.

For much of this era, **Srivijayan influence** extended over the Southeast Asian mainland, including the **Mekong basin kingdom** formerly known to the Chinese as Funan. But, in 802, **Jayavarman II**, a vassal ruler whose family had been quietly extending their territory since



Jayavarman II

This statue of Jayavarman II, from the 12th-century Bayon temple at Angkor Thom, was constructed by his namesake, Jayavarman VII.

around 770, was powerful enough to establish an independent **Khmer Empire** and have himself proclaimed *chakravartin*, or “universal ruler.” In Sanskrit this translates as “god-king”—the authority of Khmer kings rested on their direct link to the gods, which was reflected in the monuments they would construct at the temple city of Angkor in centuries to come (see 880–90).

Around 801, **Bulan**, the Khan of the Khazar Empire (see 861–70), hosted a debate between the three Abrahamic faiths, and chose **Judaism**.



Louis the Pious in a copy of Raban Maur's *Book of the Cross*.

CONFLICT BETWEEN THE BYZANTINES AND BULGARS

(see 671–90) continued through the early part of the 9th century. Despite Byzantine emperor **Nicephorus I** (r. 802–11) twice sacking the Bulgar capital Pliskas, in 809 and 811, the **Bulgar khan, Krum**, fought back, meeting his foe in battle later in 811. Nicephorus was killed and Krum had his foe's skull lined with silver for use as a drinking cup. Two years later, Krum attempted to besiege the Byzantine capital **Constantinople**, but was unable to breach the walls and so retreated, **devastating Thrace** instead.

Charlemagne (see 760–800) died in 814 and his last remaining son, **Louis the Pious** (r. 814–40), acceded to the throne. He had been crowned co-emperor by his father the year before.

ISLAMIC SCIENCE

Thanks to the House of Wisdom and other similar centers of scholarship across the Caliphate, Islamic scholars went far beyond the learning of the ancient Greeks and Romans. Islamic scientists made great advances in fields such as alchemy (proto-chemistry), medicine, toxicology, metallurgy, mathematics, and astronomy. This illustration from *The Book of Knowledge of Ingenious Mechanical Devices* shows an innovative handwashing device.



This 14th-century manuscript depicts scholars seated in the House of Wisdom; the Abbasid caliphs recruited scholars of all religions, from Europe to China.

THE HOUSE OF WISDOM, or *Bait al-Hikma*, was an institute devoted to the translation of classical scholarship and the pursuit of learning in **Abbasid Baghdad**. It was the epicenter of the Islamic intellectual renaissance, the heart of the Translation Movement, and the home of great scholars such as **Al-Kharwizmi** (c. 780–850); algebra takes its name from his great treatise on mathematics of c. 830, the *Kitab al-Jabir*, or *The Compendious Book on Calculation by Completion and Balancing*.

The House of Wisdom was consolidated c. 822 by **al-Ma'mun**. After the death of his father **Haroun al-Rashid** (see 791–800), and after a brief struggle, he had succeeded to the Caliphate in 813 and continued the tradition of intellectual patronage, building observatories and gathering the best scholars from around the



400

THOUSAND THE NUMBER OF BOOKS IN THE HOUSE OF WISDOM

world. Mimicking the practices of the Abbasid's Persian predecessors, the **Sasanians**, the **Translation Movement** collected manuscripts from other cultures and older traditions, and **translated them into Arabic**, thus preserving much ancient scholarship that would otherwise have been lost. Ptolemy's seminal work on cosmology, the *Almagest*, for instance, was translated from Greek into Arabic around 827, and it was only through this translation that European scholars would later be able to access this ancient text.

Civil strife in the **Carolingian Empire** (800–88) resulted from tension between **Louis the Pious and his sons** over their inheritances. After the death in 819 of his first wife—mother of his sons **Lothair**, **Pepin**, and **Louis the German**—Louis the Pious had married the ambitious Judith of Bavaria, who prevailed on Louis to grant to her son, **Charles the Bald** (823–77), lands that had previously been promised to **Lothair**. In retaliation, Lothair,

c. 801 In India, Gurjara-Pratihara king **Nagabhata II** conquers Kanauj

c. 801 Construction of **Borobudur temple** in Java

802 **Khmer Empire** established by **Jayavarman II**

805 Franks under **Pepin** defeat Avars in Hungary

c. 810 Islamic **algebra** system of Persian mathematician **Musa al-Khwarazmi** established

c. 801 Height of **Tibetan Empire**

c. 801 Khazarian king **Bulan** hosts debate between three Abrahamic faiths; chooses **Judaism**

802 Empress **Irene** exiled; **Nicephorus** becomes Byzantine emperor

803 Abbasid caliph **Haroun al-Rashid** destroys Barmakids

809 **Nicephorus** raids Bulgar capital Pliskas

811 **Krum** of **Bulgaria** kills **Nicephorus**

811 First paper currency “flying cash” in China

813 **Al-Ma'mun** becomes Abbasid caliph

814 Death of **Charlemagne** (born c. 742); **Louis the Pious** ascends to Frankish throne

c. 820 Founding of the **House of Wisdom** in Baghdad

825 **Norsemen** reach the Faroe Islands

825 King **Egbert** of **Wessex** defeats King **Beornwulf** at Ellendun

827 Muslim fugitives from Spain conquer **Crete** and use it as base for piracy

827 First Islamic incursion into **Sicily**

828 **Wessex** dominant in England; **Egbert** acknowledged as **bretwalda** or overlord

829 **Thai empire** of **Nanchao** expands into southern China